

Planning Context and Proposed Ohio River South Shore Trail (ORSST) Alignment

situated midway between Pittsburgh and Beaver) and Fort Vance. Robert Vance, a Virginian, had been a member of the regiment commanded by George Washington at the Braddock expedition during the French and Indian War. For the protection of himself and his neighbors, of whom several arrived within a few years, Vance had a log stockade built with a stone blockhouse to protect the area against Indian raids. Vance’s Fort was located in the area of Broadway and Chestnut Street near Second Avenue. As the Borough grew and flourished the Reverend Josiah Dillon, a pioneer clergyman, suggested the name to be changed to Coraopolis. Dillon knew Greek and was also the first burgess (mayor) at the time. It is believe that he suggested combining *Kore* meaning ‘maiden’ and *opolis* meaning ‘city’ (‘maiden city’) to achieve *Koreopolis*. When the Greek letters and pronunciation were turned to English, however, it is said that the spelling accidentally got changed to its adopted form.

Community development in Coraopolis moved along gradually with the building of the Pittsburgh and Lake Erie Railroad in 1877. Several Coraopolis residents were stockholders in this enterprise. In 1890, oil was discovered at both ends of the borough, which briefly stimulated a population boom. The effects did not last long, however, as the oil supplies were found to be rather modest.

In 1892 Pittsburgh, Neville Island and Coraopolis Railway Company was established in Coraopolis for electric street railways. Coraopolis continued to grow and many industries were constructed in the town. Along with the railway came the Consolidated Lamp and Glass Company. Consolidated Glass employed up to 350 people. Other Coraopolis residents worked for the new industries established on Neville Island. Like other heavy industrial towns, Coraopolis ultimately felt the impacts of the decline of the steel industry and many businesses closed or moved.

The portion of Coraopolis Borough that is located within the ORSST study has two sites listed on the National Register of Historic Places. Most of the ORSST Study Area consists of a very urban context in and around the central business district. Identified historic resources within the study area include:

- *Coraopolis Armory; and*
- *Coraopolis Bridge at Ferree Street and Grand Avenue (replaced in 1994 with the existing Neville Island Bridge)*

Land Use, Parks and Recreation Resources and River Access

Coraopolis Borough is a dense urban community with a traditional street grid that extends from the Ohio River’s edge, south, up to slope to the higher elevations of Moon Township. There is a mixed use area located between the CSX Railroad right-of-way which includes residential, commercial and industrial uses. The riverfront area from American Bridge Way to approximately Main Street consists of heavy industrial activities, such as petroleum tank farms and pre cast concrete component manufacturing. The area from Main Street to Chestnut Street is mostly residential, including senior, multi-family and single housing. The Borough also has its public

works facility is this area, between Bliwas Field and the Ohio River. The area east of Chestnut Street to the Neville Island Bridge consists of small scale industrial or vacant land.

Coraopolis Borough has several small parks and playgrounds facilities. The three park sites exist within this segment of the ORRST study area are all located along the Ohio River’s edge. Existing facilities located within or close to the proposed trail route include:

- *Ronald L. Bliwas Field;*
- *Riverfront Park; and*
- *Litteria Park.*

A joint effort between The Friends of the Riverfront, the Pennsylvania Environmental Council and The 3 Rivers 2nd Nature Project studied the potential of creating a network of water trails along the rivers of the Pittsburgh Region. The study recommends that at least one new public river access point for boating be created in the vicinity of the Neville Island Bridge. The proposed water trail would extend downriver to the boat launches in Sewickley and other access points along the Ohio River up river from Coraopolis.

There are several small blighted residential properties located between Riverfront Park and Litteria Park along 1st Avenue. Allegheny County owns or is in the process of acquiring these parcels. The structures on these properties should be removed and the two parks linked together, along with Bliwas Field located west of Riverfront Park, to create a continuous two-and-a-half block-long riverfront park area.

Most of the north-south streets in the Borough terminate at the Ohio River’s edge, creating potential small public riverfront access points along the Ohio River. These areas could be designed to create small riverfront overlooks or mini-parks as well as visual focal points for each of the streets.

There is a vacant former industrial parcel located along the Ohio River’s edge, near the terminus of Montour Street. It is rumored that the current owners of this parcel would like to develop a marina on the site. The site has access issues; it was once accessed via an at-grade railroad crossing along Montour Street which was removed by the CSX Railroad. The Borough could partner with the owners of this property and the owners of the adjacent Montour Industrial Supply to create a new public access road which extends 3rd Avenue into in the proposed marina site. As part of this project, trail access through this parcel to several undevelopable riverfront parcels east of the Neville Island Bridge could be acquired as well as having a piece of the marina site dedicated for river access. A future trail connection could extend east to Royal Avenue, adjacent to the CSX Railroad right-of-way, creating a long linear riverfront public park. This is described in more detail under Alternative 600B.

Section 600 - Coraopolis Borough – Moon Township (Existing Montour Trail Milepost “0”)

Community Character and Demographic Overview

Coraopolis Borough comprises an area of 1.36 sq. miles and lies along the Ohio River, about 15 miles Northwest of Pittsburgh. The Borough has approximately 1 mile of Ohio River frontage, all within Section 600.

Coraopolis Borough consists of approximately 6,131 people and 2,880 households. The racial makeup of the area is 84.9 percent White, 12.4 percent African American, 0.98 percent Hispanic, 0.08 percent Native American, and 0.02 percent Asian. The per capital income of the town is \$17,595 and 9.7 percent of the population lives below the poverty line, slightly lower than Pennsylvania’s rate of 12.1 percent.

History and Cultural Resources

On April 3, 1769, Andrew Montour, an Indian interpreter who had provided service to English settlers during the French and Indian War, was granted a land patent for approximately 350 acres of what would later become the Borough of Coraopolis and Neville Island. Andrew Montour is the namesake of Montour Run which runs along the eastern boundary of the Borough.

At one time Coraopolis had two other names, Middletown (because it was

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Environmental Context and Infrastructure

River’s Edge and Habitat: As is the case with many of the older urbanized areas along the Ohio River, most of the river’s edge has been developed either for major industrial or pockets of residential development. In the case of Coraopolis Borough, the Ohio River’s edge is fairly well vegetated. This is partly a result of major portions either being residential or publicly owned. Much of the riverfront area also serves as the Borough’s water supply well access area. Reducing development, especially industrial activities in this area is extremely important for well-head protection.

There is very little bulkheading of the Ohio River’s edge in this area, allowing for a natural river “toe” which makes for a more natural river ecosystem. There is a moderate topographic change between the Ohio River’s mean water elevation and the developed areas of the Borough, making potential water edge access easier here than along other portions of the ORSST study area.

Streams and Stormwater: McCabe Run is a day-lighted stream course that drains into the Ohio River within Coraopolis Borough. The stream is located along Montour Street. It travels down a narrow valley through a residential area to 5th Avenue. It travels towards Arch Street and then through culverts located under 5th and 4th Avenues with a small day-lighted portion between the two streets that could be enhanced as part of a small mini-park and stormwater infiltration area. From 4th Avenue, the stream travels through a culvert under the CSX Railroad and is again day-lighted until it reaches the Ohio River.

Montour Run is a major regional stream that serves a large sub watershed area. This stream runs parallel to the Montour Trail through a broad valley. The lower portion of the stream passes through the Montour Junction/ Sports Legacy property. This large property consists of a series of parcels that were formerly a railroad maintenance facility. Allegheny County is in the process of acquiring these properties with the intention of creating a large multi-use park and recreational complex. The stream through this area shows signs of major disturbance as a result of the former industrial activities. In addition there are large low areas within this overall parcel that appear to be wetlands which experience flooding on a regular basis. Any development on this site should integrate the ability to retain stormwater that runs down the valley from the upland developed areas, prior to discharging into the Ohio River. In addition, future recreational facilities, such as sport fields could be designed to accommodate stormwater in the event of major floods. The extension of the Montour Trail to Montour Street through this area may not be best located on the former railroad rail bed, since it is located very close to Montour Run in many locations. This may be a location that is more prone to flooding and washouts. Montour Run travels through a very large culvert underneath the CSX Railroad before discharging into the Ohio River.

As with many older urban communities, much of the Borough’s sewage system consists of combined sewer outfalls (CSOs). Opportunities to reduce stormwater flowing directly into the sewer system through improved site-specific infiltration projects that help to alleviate CSO impacts on

the environment should be integrated into trail design projects wherever possible.

Transportation Infrastructure

PA Route 51 travels through the Borough primarily via 4th and 5th Avenue. These two roadways function as one-way pairs, with 4th Avenue serving westbound traffic and 5th Avenue serving eastbound traffic. 4th Avenue has an average daily traffic volume of approximately 9,400. 5th Avenue has an average daily traffic volumes ranging from approximately 9,000 to 11,000 depending on the segment. PA Route 51/State Avenue, located on the eastern edge of the Borough, has an average daily traffic volume of 12,000.

PA Route 51 is designated by PennDOT as the Pennsylvania Bicycle Route A through the Borough of Coraopolis. Both 4th and 5th Avenues have sidewalks on both sides throughout the downtown, and in many cases they are wider than 10’.

The streets located between the CSX Railroad and the Ohio River’s edge could all be classified as a neighborhood street network with little through traffic. Nearly all of the streets have sidewalks and on-street parking on both sides.

Some of the roadways in the western industrial area, such as Birch Avenue, are in poor condition and are in need of improvement, including reconstruction, curbing, drainage and streetscaping.

Economic Development

Allegheny County Economic Development (ACED) is the lead economic and residential development agency for Allegheny County. ACED provides a variety of services such as loan programs and site selection services in addition to sponsoring a variety of State and Federal funding programs.

Over the past few months, Coraopolis has held three community Key Issue Workshops. These workshops are a component of the Allegheny Together Program, a program offered through ACED to support and assist in the revitalization of traditional downtown-based business districts throughout the County. Coraopolis is one of the 43 business districts located within Allegheny County that are eligible for the Allegheny Together Program. In 2009, Coraopolis was one of two new community applicants selected by the County to be added to the program-- bringing the current number of participating towns to eight. All of the participating communities are being provided a host of planning and management services through Town Center Associates (TCA) and the Pittsburgh History and Landmarks Foundation (PHLF) and their planning consultants, via the Allegheny Together Program.

Allegheny Together endeavors to encourage well-planned, well-designed and geographically-focused investment in the established, urban commercial districts of Allegheny County while respecting the unique history, character, and built environment of each. The program aims to help

organize and empower each community to fulfill its collective vision. The creation of the Ohio River Trail through Coraopolis, connecting the Borough to the future Allegheny County Regional Park on the Montour Junction/Sports Legacy site, the 47 mile Montour Trail to the east, and the Moon Township’s proposed waterfront park and further trail extensions to the west have been designated by Coraopolis as a top priority initiatives through the Allegheny Together Program workshops.

Proposed ORSST Route and Alternatives

Proposed ORSST Route Description through Section 600

The proposed route through Section 600 would travel from Moon Township/ Coraopolis Borough Line at Thorn Run Road to the existing Montour Trail Mile Post “0” in Moon Township, via American Bridge Way, 3rd Avenue Right-of-Way (vacant), Watt Street, Birch Avenue, Kendall Street, 1st Avenue, Broadway, Pine Alley, Montour Street, and the Montour Junction/Sports Legacy Foundation Property. The proposed trail is predominately a signed on-road route through the Borough of Coraopolis with a 10’ wide multi-use trail connection at Montour Street to the existing Montour Trail, through the Montour Junction/Sport Legacy Foundation property.

Route Characteristics and Issues

3rd Avenue: The ownership of the right-of-way for 3rd Avenue between the American Bridge property and the CSX Railroad right-of-way from American Bridge Way to Watt Street needs to be clarified. There is



Existing 3rd Avenue Right-of-Way

conflicting information regarding the existence of the public right-of-way along this segment.

Birch Avenue: This roadway is in poor condition and will need to be fully reconstructed. The need for businesses which have frontage along Birch Avenue to have access via their rear gates for vehicular traffic should be determined. If access is not needed this segment could become a bicycle

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Birch Avenue

dedicated segment with a 10' wide trail and urban stormwater rain garden facility between Watt Street and Kendall Street.

1st Avenue: 1st Avenue is the main residential street that is closest and parallel to the Ohio River in Coraopolis. It is targeted as an on-road route and will only require trailblazing signing and possibly some traffic calming measures since some vehicular speeding was witnessed during



1st Avenue

field observations. Broadway Street is a residential street and will only require on-road trailblazer signing.

Pine Alley: A key component of the ORSST route through Coraopolis is an on-road “green alley” route through the downtown, via Pine Alley. Pine Alley will feature safety improvements including striping and lighting as well as improved streetscaping and site specific stormwater

management improvements to promote better urban stormwater runoff management. The on-road route through this segment could be initially signed with trailblazer signing, however, this segment also represents an excellent route for the core of Coraopolis to access the pending Montour Junction Recreation Complex located at the east end of the Borough. Any streetscaping and/or urban design recommendations as part of the



Pine Alley

Allegheny Together Program Plan for the Borough should be incorporated into this corridor as an important pedestrian/bicycle spine.

Montour Street from 4th Avenue to the Montour Junction Access Point Adjacent to the CSX Railroad Mainline. This small segment is a critical link between the core downtown area of the Borough and the future park on the Montour Junction property. This route should be signed once the Montour Junction property is publicly accessible. The area is targeted as an on-road route, however, additional safety improvements should be considered for the intersection of 4th Avenue and Montour Street. These improvements could include curb bump outs, enhanced crosswalk striping and crossing warning signals.

Proposed Route Lengths

Coraopolis Borough On-Road Portion = 1.2 miles

Coraopolis Borough 10' Wide Multi Use Path = .86 miles (this segment through the Montour Junction Property may be owned and maintained by Allegheny County)

Total Length of Route through Coraopolis Borough (all of Section 600) = 2.1 miles

Identified ORSST Routing Alternatives in Section 600

Alternative 600A

Description: This alternative consists of routing bicycle traffic along 4th and 5th Avenue.

Issues and Opportunities: 4th Avenue is currently a wide one-way roadway

with two through-travel lanes and parking on both sides. After multiple site visits and field observations were performed, cross section studies were developed for the possible integration of bicycle facilities along each roadway. It appears that the parking along this roadway is rarely utilized. One option considered included the removal of the parking lane on the river's side of the roadway and replacing it with a 6' wide bike lane and 3' shoulder.

In contrast, 5th Avenue has one wide through-lane and parking on both sides. The roadway is not wide enough to accommodate a dedicated bike lane and it appears that parking is well utilized on both sides of this street. This route could be designated as a “sharrow” with special roadway marking down the middle of the travel lane to make motorists aware of the shared roadway conditions. One issue with this alternative is the short one-way segment of Mill Street between 4th and 5th Avenues. The proposed on-road route would travel south on Mill Street towards 4th Avenue. Currently Mill Street is one-way in the opposite direction. This one-way segment would need to be reversed; otherwise the on-road route would need to travel along Main Street. It was determined that Alternative 600A was feasible but the not desirable due to the high traffic volumes on both streets as well as implications of the one-way street network.

Alternative 600B

Description: This alternative consists of a short on-road segment and a 10' wide multi-use path along the riverfront from Chestnut Street to Royal Avenue in Robinson Township.

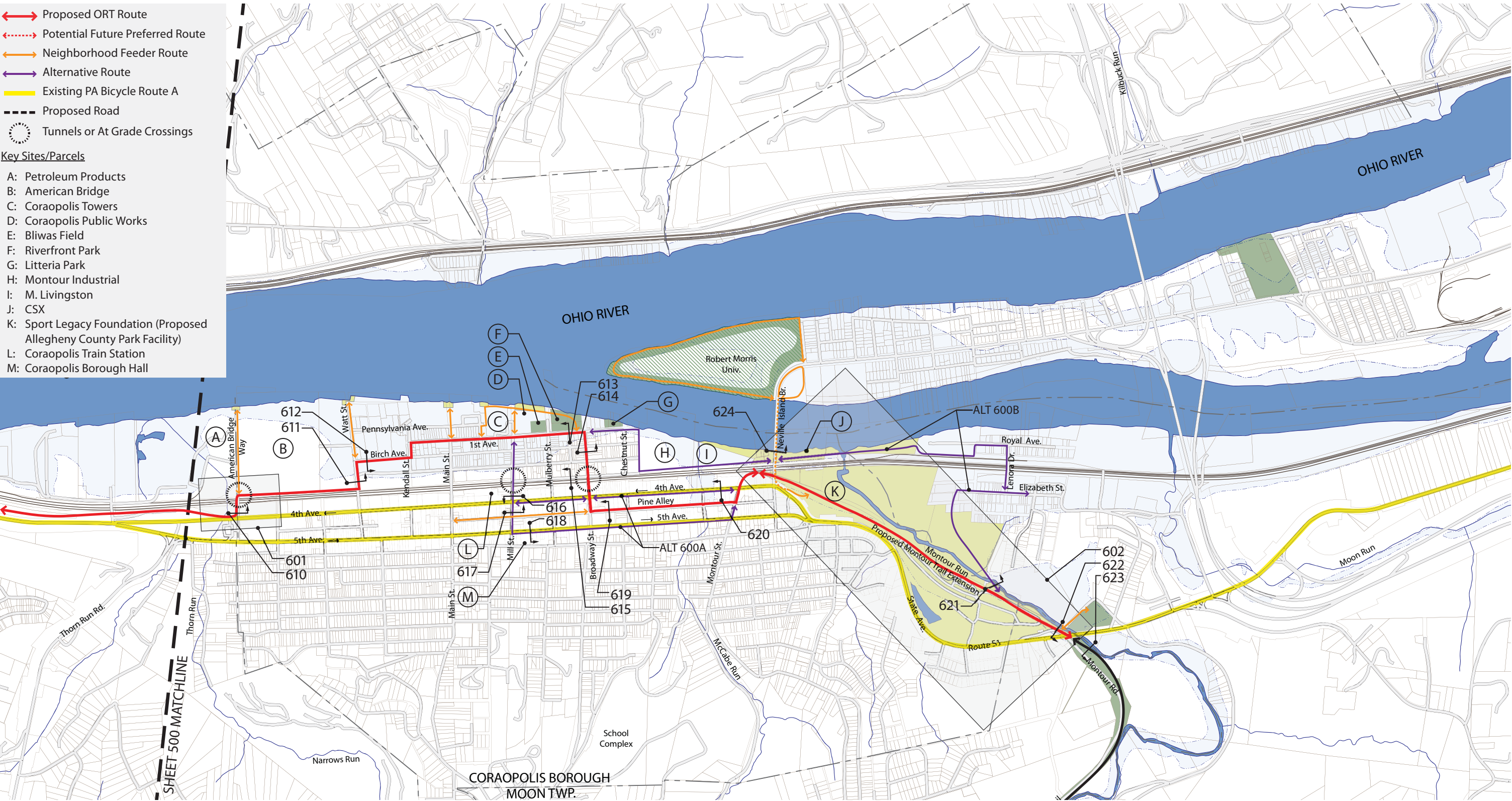
Issues and Opportunities: Alternative 600B represents a very desirable trail connection along the River's edge and the opportunity to compliment the proposed Montour Junction/Sports Legacy Recreation Complex on Ohio River side of the CSX Railroad. There are several complicated issues with this alternative which make it less desirable as a near-term alternative route; however, opportunities exist to create this very desirable route long-term. It is believed that the current owners of Parcel “I” as shown on the Section 600 Routing Plan are exploring ways to develop a marina and boat launch on the site. There are access issues to the property which currently limits the ability to develop the parcel. If 3rd Avenue, as a public roadway, could be extended from Chestnut Street to the site, it would provide the access needed for the development of the parcel and allow the creation of a key trail connection through two major parcels along the riverfront. Once access to the potential marina site is achieved, it opens up several additional properties owned by the CSX Railroad and PennDOT that are not suitable for railroad or other development activities. These parcels could be the location of a new linear riverfront park creating an area with parkland on both sides of the Ohio River channel, with Robert Morris University's recreation complex located on the opposite side of the Ohio River's back channel.

LEGEND

- Proposed ORT Route
- Potential Future Preferred Route
- Neighborhood Feeder Route
- Alternative Route
- Existing PA Bicycle Route A
- Proposed Road
- Tunnels or At Grade Crossings

Key Sites/Parcels

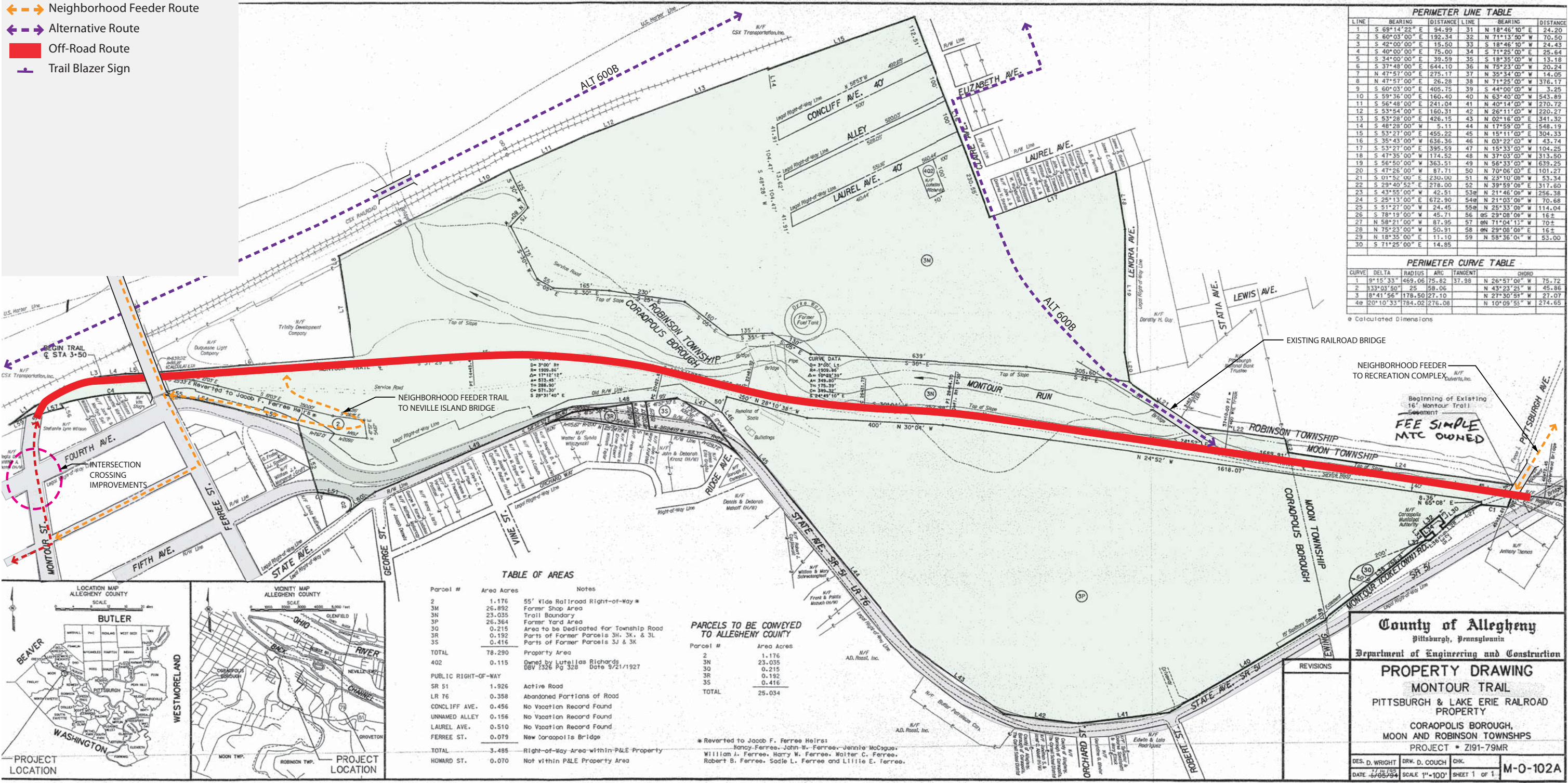
- A: Petroleum Products
- B: American Bridge
- C: Coraopolis Towers
- D: Coraopolis Public Works
- E: Bliwas Field
- F: Riverfront Park
- G: Litteria Park
- H: Montour Industrial
- I: M. Livingston
- J: CSX
- K: Sport Legacy Foundation (Proposed Allegheny County Park Facility)
- L: Coraopolis Train Station
- M: Coraopolis Borough Hall



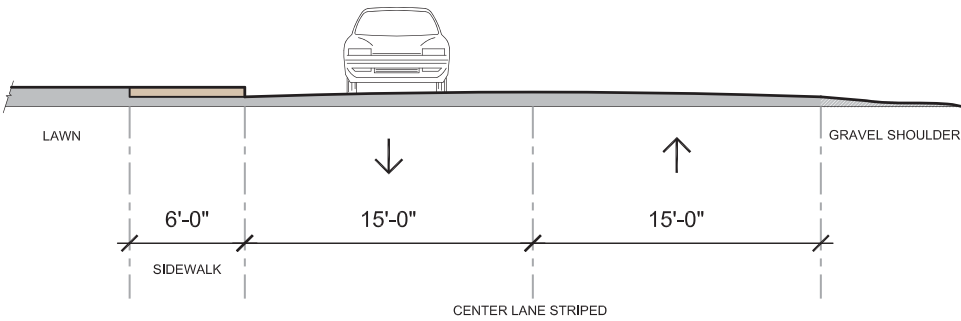
SCALE: Not to Scale NORTH

LEGEND

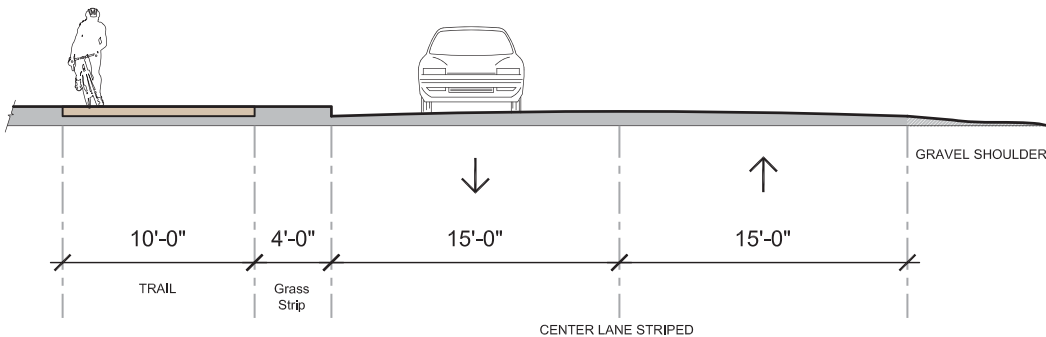
- Signed On-Road Route
- Neighborhood Feeder Route
- Alternative Route
- Off-Road Route
- Trail Blazer Sign



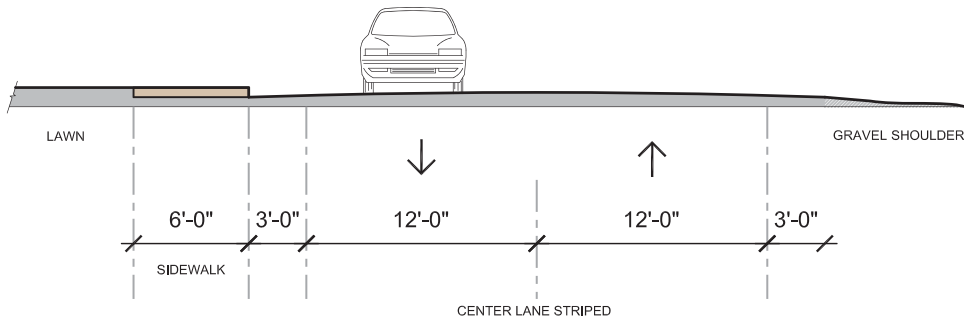
602 SCALE: Not to Scale



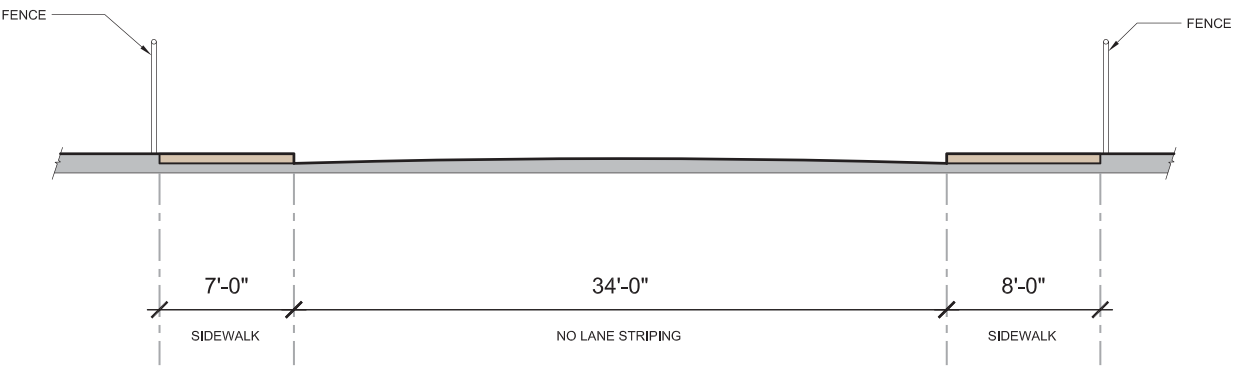
610 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - AMERICAN BRIDGE WAY LOOKING TOWARD 4TH AVE. (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



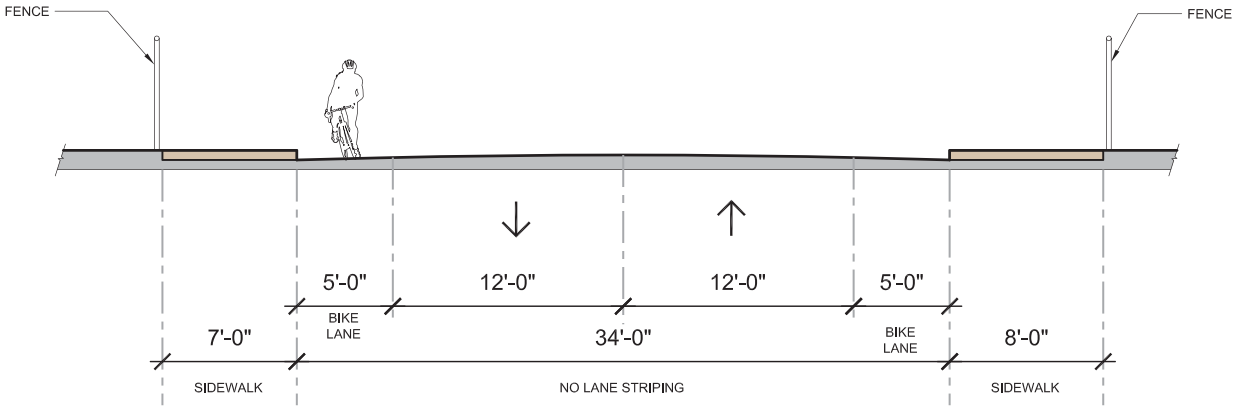
610 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - AMERICAN BRIDGE WAY
LOOKING TOWARD 4TH AVE.
SCALE: 1"=10' (PROPOSED OPTION A)



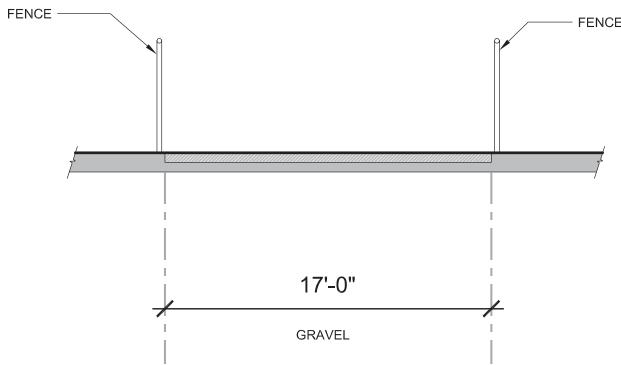
610 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - AMERICAN BRIDGE WAY
LOOKING TOWARD 4TH AVE.
SCALE: 1"=10' (PROPOSED OPTION B)



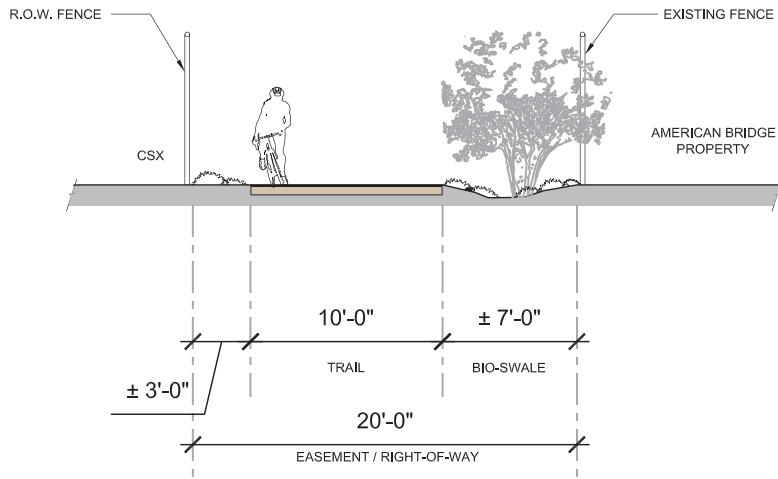
611 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - WATT ST. LOOKING NORTH (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



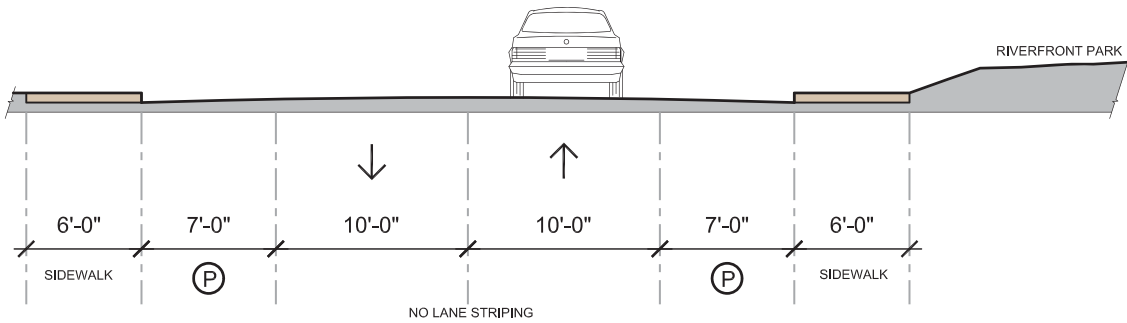
611 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - WATT ST. LOOKING NORTH (PROPOSED)
SCALE: 1"=10'



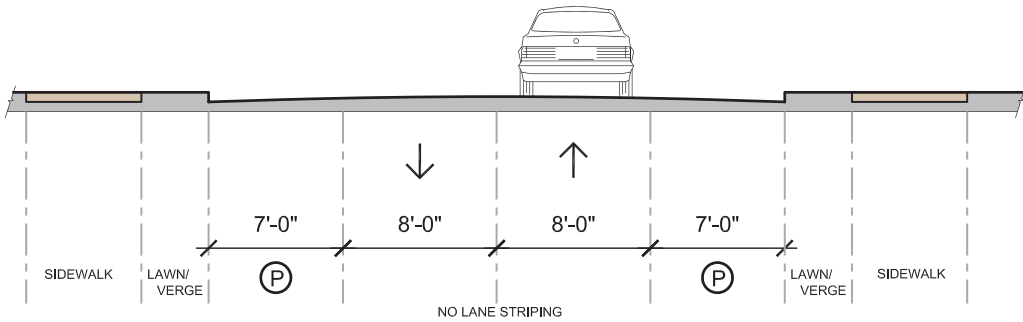
612 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - BIRCH WAY BETWEEN WATT ST. & MAIN ST. (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



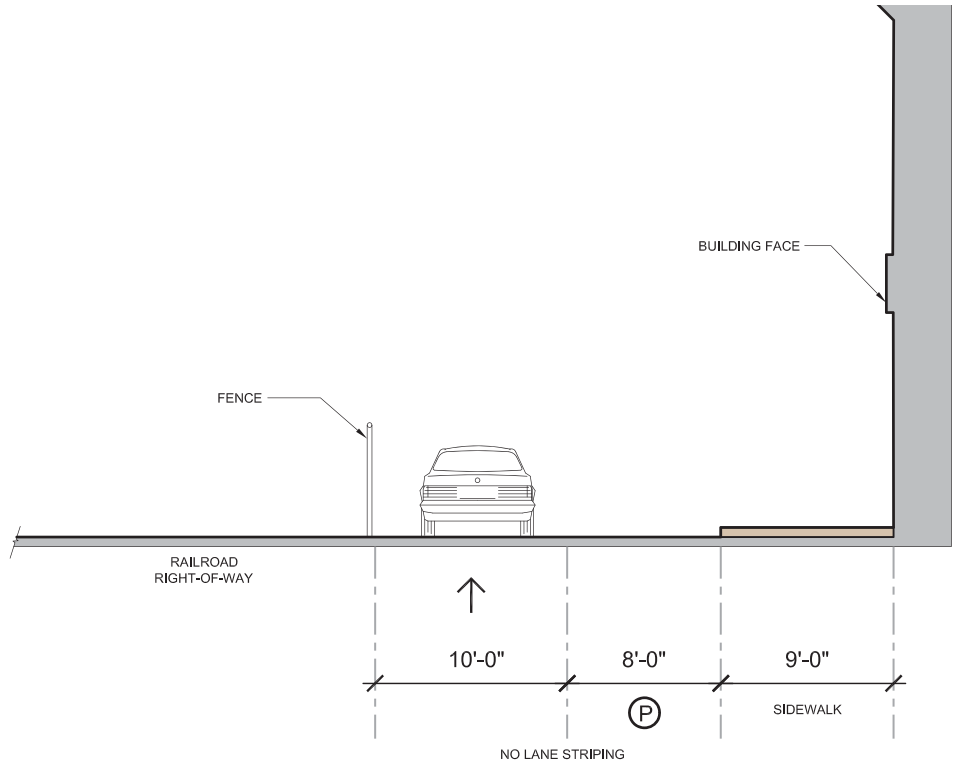
612 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - BIRCH WAY BETWEEN WATT ST. & AMERICAN BRIDGE WAY - LOOKING WEST (PROPOSED)
SCALE: 1"=10'



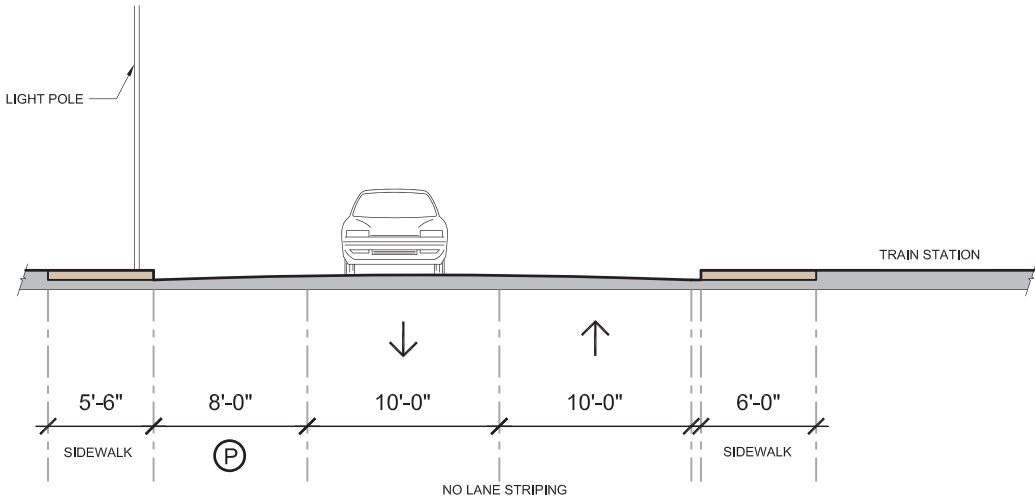
613 CORAOPOLIS BORO. -1ST AVE AT BROADWAY ST. LOOKING WEST (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



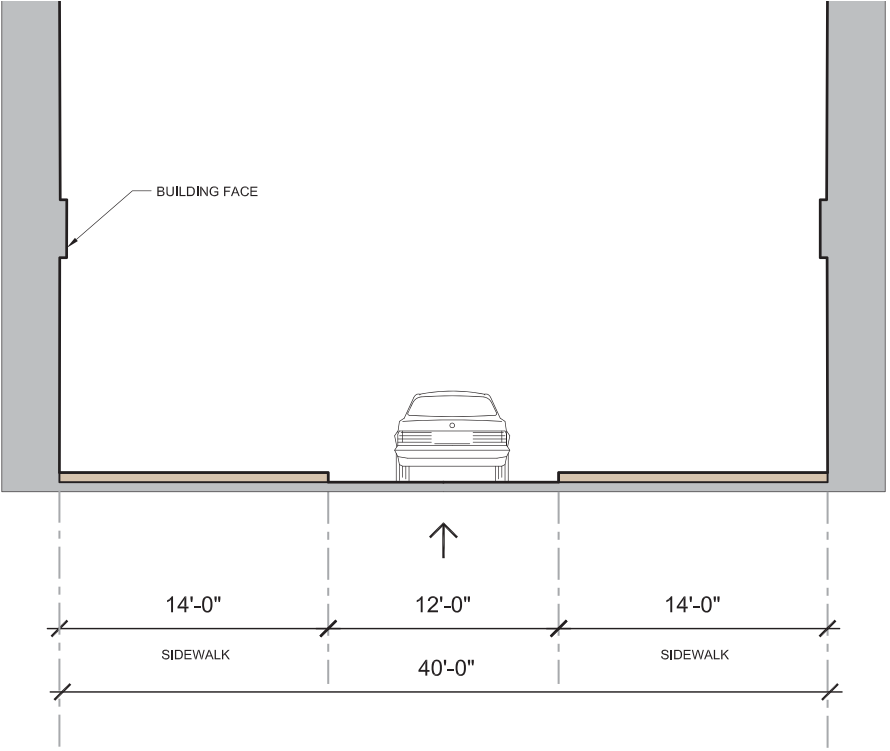
614 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - BROADWAY ST. LOOKING NORTH (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



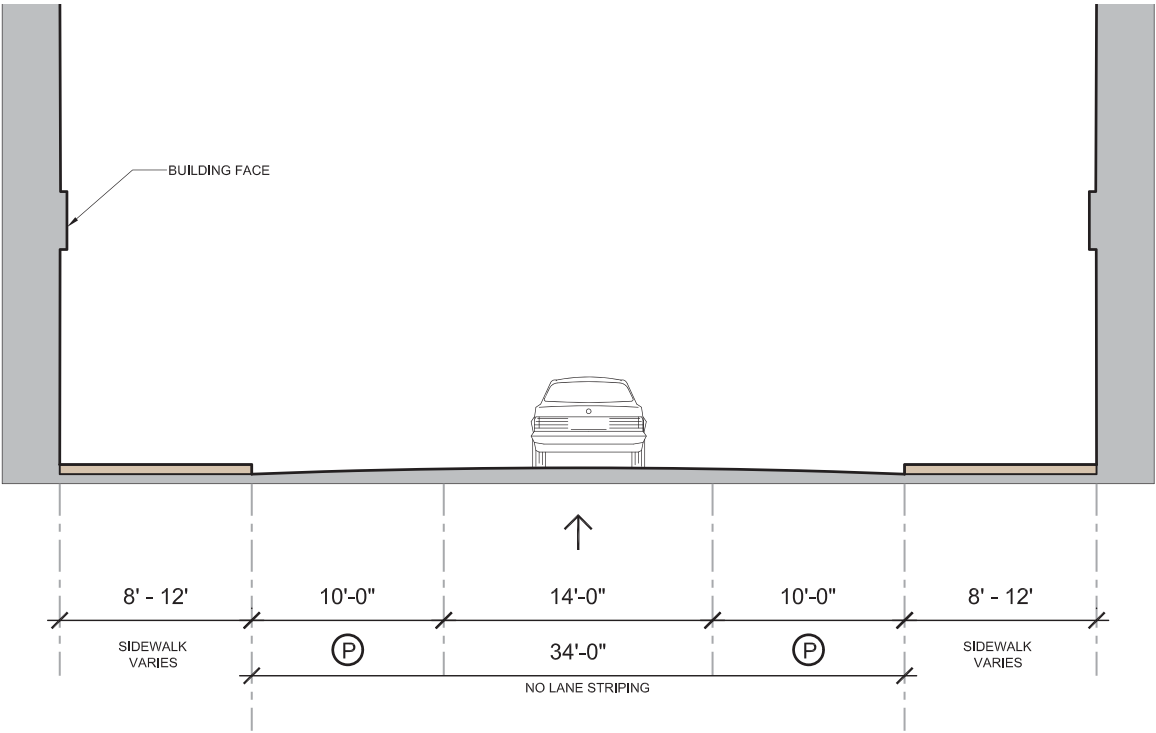
615 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - 3RD AVE AT MULBERRY ST. LOOKING WEST (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



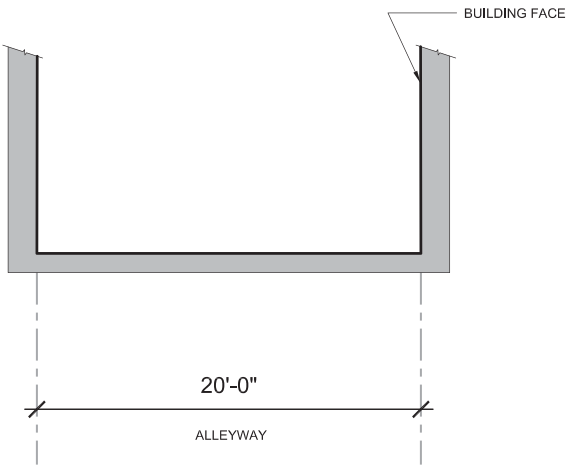
616 CORAOPOLIS BORO. -MILL ST. AT TRAIN STATION LOOKING TOWARDS 4TH AVE. (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



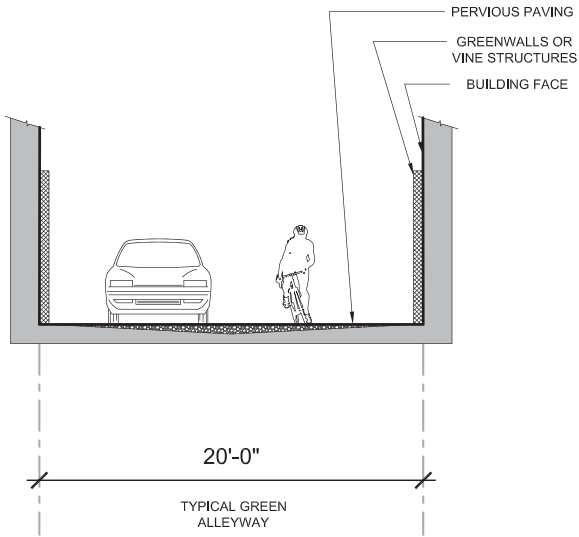
617 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - MILL ST. AT INTERSECTION WITH 4TH AVE. LOOKING NORTH (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



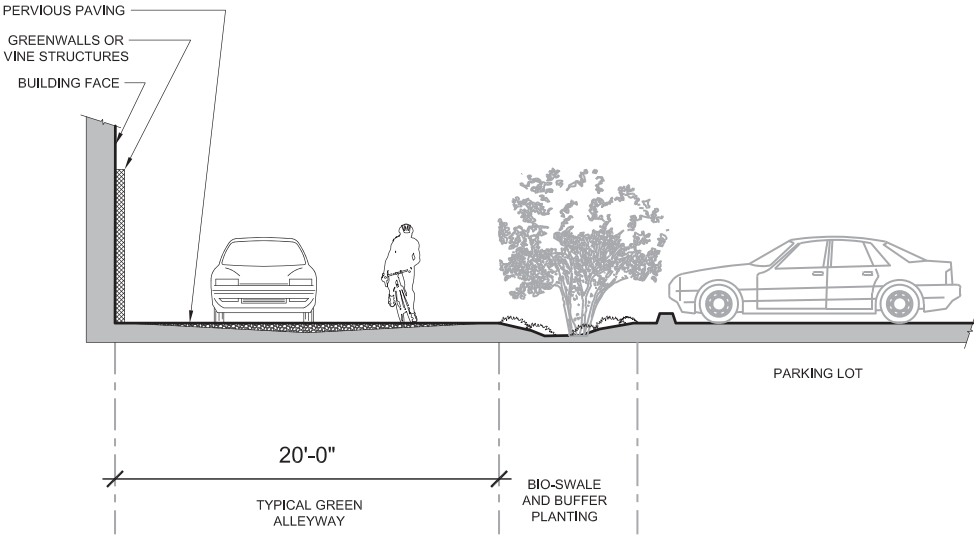
618 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - 5TH AVE AT MILL ST. LOOKING EAST (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



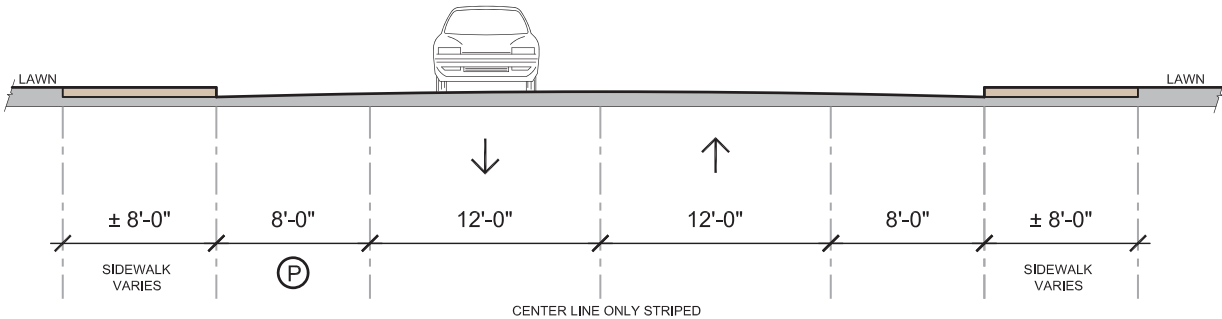
619 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - TYPICAL ALLEYWAY BETWEEN 4TH & 5TH AVENUE (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



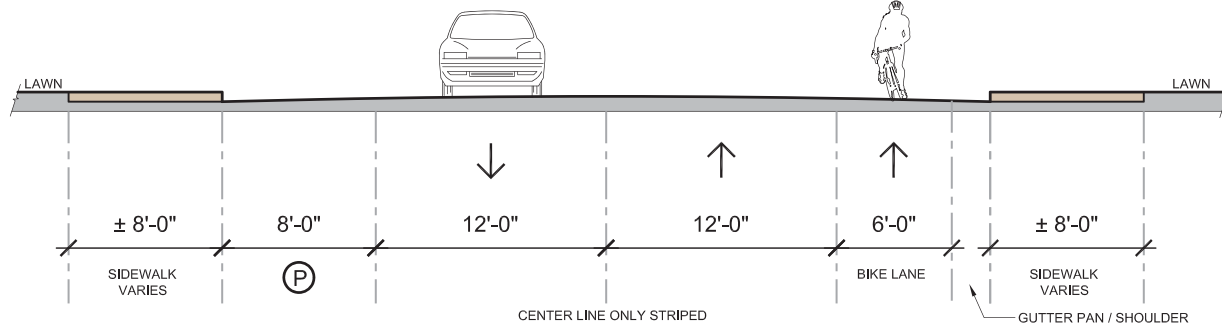
619 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - TYPICAL ALLEYWAY BETWEEN 4TH & 5TH AVENUE (PROPOSED)
SCALE: 1"=10'



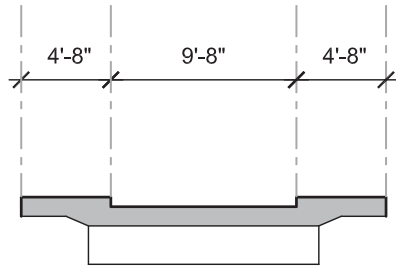
619 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - GREEN ALLEYWAY WITH PARKING LOT (PROPOSED)
SCALE: 1"=10'



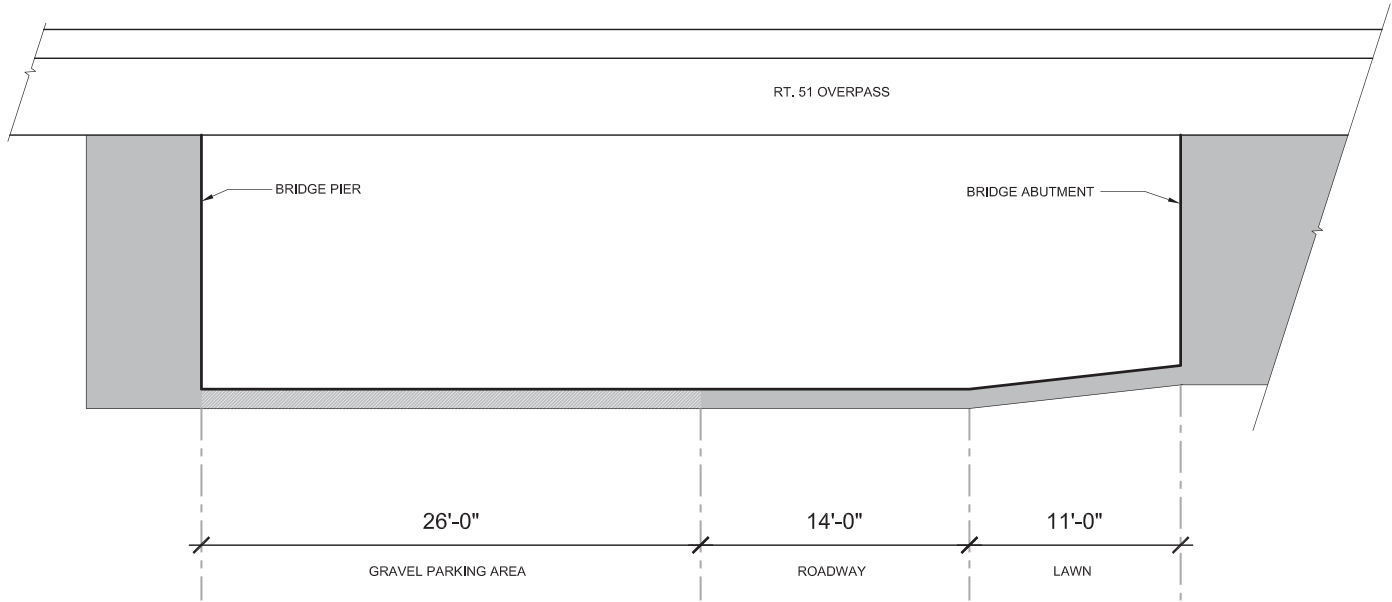
620 CORAOPOLIS BORO. - 4TH AVENUE AT MONTOUR ST. LOOKING WEST (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



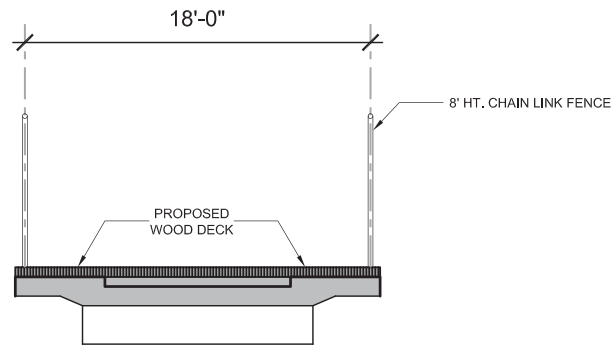
620 CORAOPOLIS BORO. -4TH AVENUE AT MONTOUR ST. LOOKING WEST (PROPOSED)
SCALE: 1"=10'



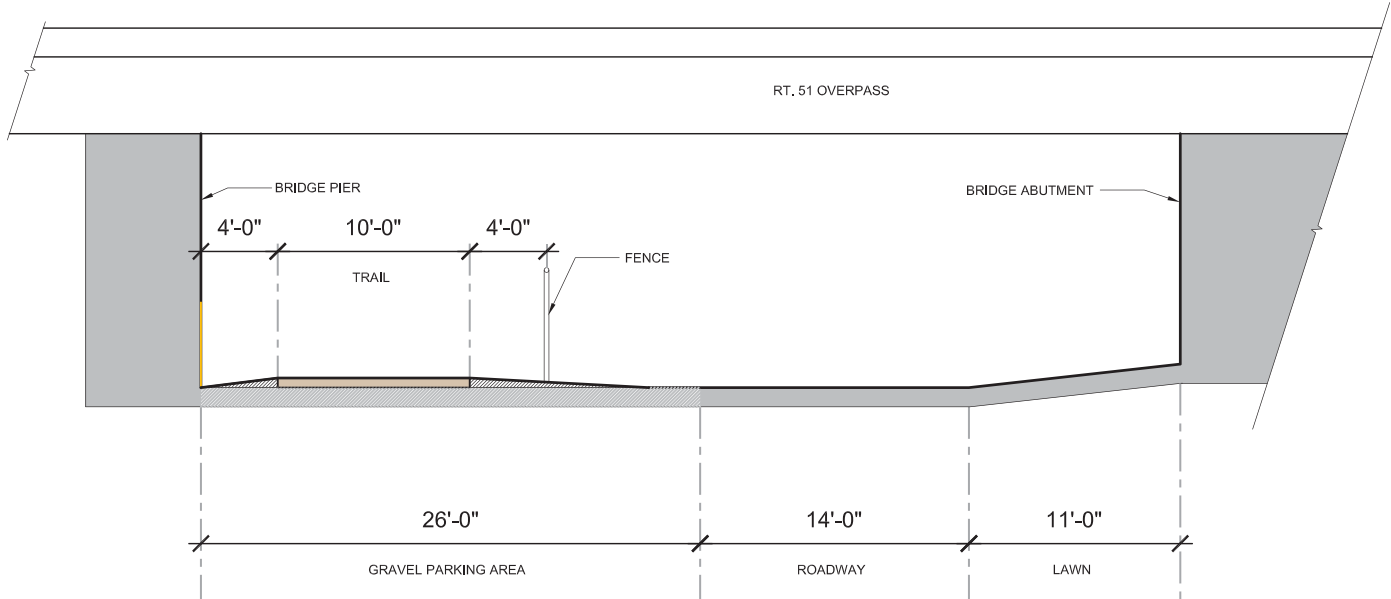
621 MONTOUR JUNCTION. - STEEL AND CONCRETE BRIDGE SPAN OVER MONTOUR RUN (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



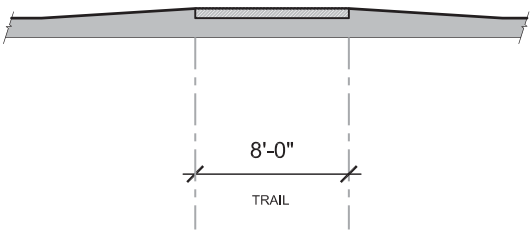
622 MONTOUR JUNCTION - MONTOUR RD. UNDER RT 51 LOOKING SOUTH (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



621 MONTOUR JUNCTION. - STEEL AND CONCRETE BRIDGE SPAN OVER MONTOUR RUN (PROPOSED)
SCALE: 1"=10'

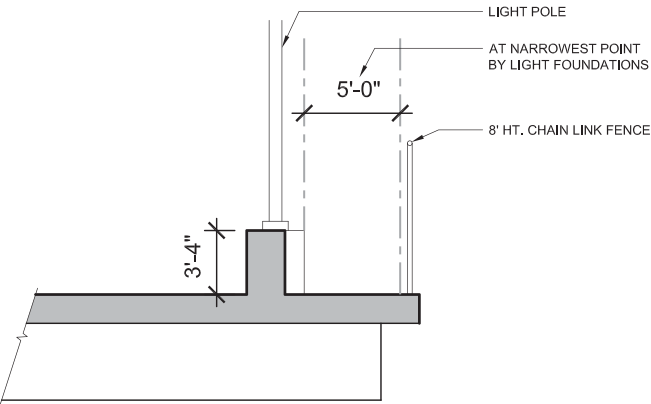


622 MONTOUR JUNCTION - MONTOUR RD. UNDER RT 51 LOOKING SOUTH (PROPOSED)
SCALE: 1"=10'



623

MONTOUR JUNCTION. - MONTOUR TRAIL
MILEPOST "0"(EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'

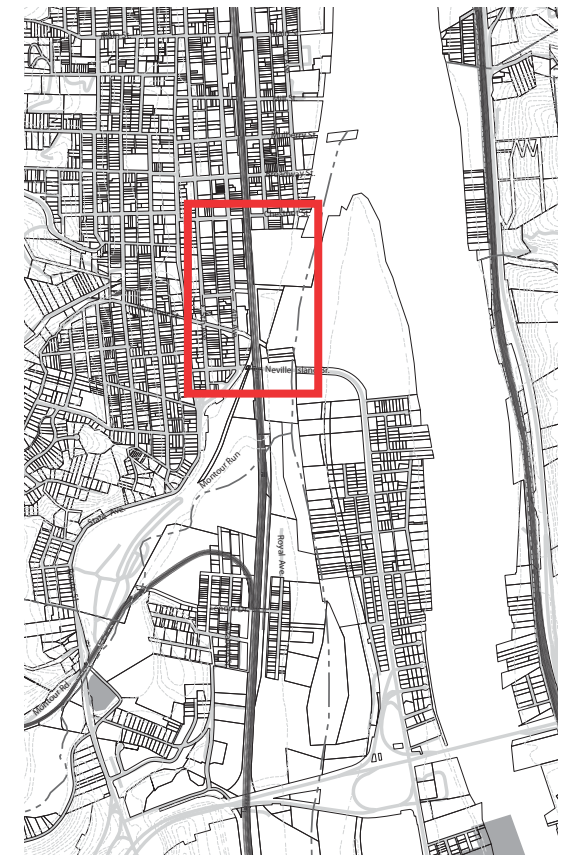


624

MONTOUR JUNCTION. - NEVILLE ISLAND BRIDGE SIDEWALK
EAST SIDE (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'

LEGEND

- Proposed 10' Wide Multi-Use Path Trail Route
- - - Proposed On-Road Signed Trail Route
- Neighborhood Feeder 10' Wide Side Path Trail Route
- - - Neighborhood Feeder On-Road Signed Trail Route
- Alternative 10' Wide Multi-Use Path Trail Route
- - - Alternative On-Road Signed Trail Route



630 Proposed Trail Location
SCALE: Not to Scale

Site Photo Location